

Dairy farmer Sarah Parker from Undera, Victoria, has been described as wearing many hats – volunteering for numerous organisations for the betterment of her community and the greater industry. All while running a full-time dairy with her husband, Raymond.

Sarah is part of the Future Drought Fund's Drought Resilient Leaders Mentoring program. As both a mentor and mentee, she has gained valuable perspectives and connections within the community.

Having experienced drought and fires on her dairy farm and impacting the industry roles that she serves in, Sarah admits to having reached a stage of disaster fatigue.

“Being drought resilient means having the capacity and capability to continue operating our dairy farm during drought. It also means being able to continue being a productive and contributing member and leader of my industry and community when the times are challenging.

Drought resilience is not just a phrase but a mindset, with skills and knowledge, strategies and support networks that enable you to function, contribute and lead in times that are challenging – this is the very essence of the mentoring program.

“The program was a real eye opener to think about and focus on how it is important to build my own resilience to help build up others. Taking care of self is important for us to function at a higher level. A resilient and healthy business owner, community member means a resilient and healthy business and community,” she said.

Sarah is a community leader and recommends the Drought Resilience Leaders Programs to all who live in regional communities.

“The opportunity to access and have a mentor is priceless. The opportunity to take stock of your situation in a supported environment and focus on personal development is one not to miss.”

The support is vital to improve the connections and networks within regional communities and leadership is critical to the resilience of the people and the community more broadly.

Sarah explained her experience has shown that leaders help people look forward and remain positive. But in addition to the broader improvement, the program assists individuals with their personal growth.

“After completing the program, I discovered who I truly was again. Going into the program I had a lot of self-doubt and confusion. My mentor helped me talk and work through this.

“She guided me through the discovery and growth process, as well as challenging my thoughts/beliefs of who I was. At the end of the mentoring and the program I had more confidence, had practiced and put into action a process of where I say no, refer to others and do not take everything on. I can also focus on what is important and ‘block’ out the noise.”